

COMPLETE CASE WALKTHROUGH

Working Backwards Practical Playbook

A concise reference for product and technology teams

Working Backwards in one sentence

Start with a specific customer outcome, write the future experience before the mechanism, expose the hardest unknowns, and make the next decision explicit.

Use the method when

1. The customer problem, success signal, or product boundary is still ambiguous.
2. Product, technology, operations, policy, or quality must make one coherent promise together.
3. The decision creates meaningful customer exposure, investment, or difficult-to-reverse architecture.
4. Important assumptions about value, feasibility, quality, accessibility, safety, or economics remain untested.

Use a lighter approach when

The change is routine, low-risk, easily reversible, and already supported by clear customer evidence and decision ownership. Keep the customer outcome and decision record, even when the full PR/FAQ is unnecessary.

The complete process at a glance

The sequence creates a chain of reasoning. Repeat an earlier step whenever evidence weakens the promise or a hard FAQ changes the boundary.

Step	Question to answer	What to do	Finished output
1	Frame the customer and outcome	Name one specific customer situation, the present struggle, and an observable outcome. Avoid broad personas and solution language.	Customer / struggle / outcome statement
2	Write the future promise	Describe the headline, benefit, experience, success signal, boundary, and fallback as if the experience already exists.	Future press release and experience narrative
3	Ask the hard FAQs	Challenge customer recovery, accessibility, feasibility, architecture, operations, quality, safety, abuse, policy, data, and economics.	Completed FAQs with guardrails and refusal conditions
4	Label uncertainty	Separate evidence, assumptions, experiments, and decisions. Record source, date, population, method, limitations, impact, and owner.	Evidence and assumption ledger
5	Recommend the next decision	Choose test, invest, pause, or stop. Make the recommendation proportional to the evidence and define entry, exit, and stop conditions.	Bounded recommendation and staged evidence plan
6	Set decision rights	Name one DRI, required contributors, the ratifying sponsor, reversibility, dissent, deadline, and review checkpoint.	Written decision record

CORE DISCIPLINE Promise first, mechanism second. Architecture, operations, and policy are evaluated against the intended experience rather than becoming the experience.

Quality gates for a decision-ready PR/FAQ

A polished narrative is not enough. The document is useful only when it improves the next decision and makes refusal conditions visible.

1. Promise

5. The customer, struggle, benefit, and observable outcome form one coherent statement.
6. The experience covers request, confirmation, fulfillment or handoff, status, and recovery.
7. The mechanism supports the promise but does not replace it.

2. Evidence

8. Observed evidence is sourced, dated, bounded, and accompanied by limitations.
9. Targets are labeled as targets; they are not presented as baselines or proof.
10. Every high-impact assumption has a credible learning method and owner.

3. Boundary and guardrails

11. In-scope and out-of-scope conditions are specific enough to protect the learning question.
12. Fallback, accessibility, quality, safety, privacy, policy, and economic controls are explicit.
13. Entry criteria, stop conditions, and the person with stop authority are named.

4. Ownership and finish line

14. One DRI integrates input and owns the recommendation; contributors own their evidence.
15. A sponsor ratifies hard-to-reverse customer exposure, policy, or investment.
16. The decision, dissent, remaining risk, next action, deadline, and review checkpoint are recorded.

READY FOR THE NEXT DECISION A reader can state the promise, the strongest evidence, the highest-impact unknown, the protected boundary, the DRI, and exactly what happens next.

Roles and decision ownership

Input stays broad; accountability stays singular. The exact titles may vary, but each responsibility must have one named owner.

Role	Primary responsibility	Decision contribution
Product Manager / initiative DRI	Customer outcome, PR/FAQ coherence, boundary, and integrated recommendation.	Ensures the complete narrative leads to one explicit decision.
Product Design	Experience evidence, comprehension, accessibility, fallback, and prototype learning.	Makes the future experience concrete enough to test.
Engineering Manager	Capacity, delivery health, staffing, dependencies, and execution risk.	Confirms whether the learning and delivery plan is responsible.
Tech Lead	Technical direction, architecture, integration risk, and technical experiments.	Recommends the technical learning path before hard-to-reverse commitments.
Engineers	Implementation evidence, scoped options, instrumentation, and recovery behavior.	Produce evidence for concrete technical choices.
QA	Release-confidence evidence, failure modes, guardrails, and stop recommendations.	Protects the promise under realistic failure conditions.
Data	Metric definitions, baselines, segmentation, measurement validity, and evidence review.	Prevents targets and noisy signals from being treated as proof.
Operations / service owners	Capacity, custody, handling, support recovery, and operating controls.	Validates the end-to-end experience outside the product interface.
Risk / policy / legal	Fairness, privacy, abuse controls, obligations, and transparent fallback.	Defines conditions the solution must not violate.
Battle-Owner	Ratification of difficult-to-reverse investment, policy, or customer exposure.	Owens the organizational commitment beyond the initiative DRI.

DRI RULE One DRI does not mean one contributor. Specialists own evidence in their domains; the DRI integrates it, records the recommendation, and owns the result.

Common failure modes and key takeaways

Common failure modes

17. **Mechanism first:** Architecture or process is proposed before the customer outcome and experience are agreed.
18. **Customer too broad:** A generic segment hides different needs, eligibility rules, and recovery paths.
19. **Target presented as evidence:** An ambition is mistaken for a measured baseline or validated threshold.
20. **FAQs used as reassurance:** Questions defend the concept instead of exposing reasons to refuse or narrow it.
21. **Consensus replaces ownership:** Many people contribute, but nobody integrates input and owns the decision.
22. **Exposure expands too quickly:** A live promise starts before cheaper customer, technical, or operational evidence is available.
23. **No written stop rule:** The team can start a pilot but cannot explain who pauses it, when, or why.

Four habits to carry into real decisions

24. **Customer first:** Name a specific struggle and an observable outcome.
25. **Future promise:** Write the experience and honest boundary before the mechanism.
26. **Evidence:** Label assumptions and run the cheapest credible tests.
27. **Ownership:** Name one DRI, write the decision, and use a sponsor for hard-to-reverse commitments.

How the document set fits together

Document	Best use
Case Walkthrough Deck	Presents the complete process and the illustrative Instant Exchange case.
Presenter Guide	Provides slide-by-slide explanations, suggested wording, likely questions, and transitions.
Practical Playbook	Serves as the concise reusable process reference after the presentation.
Completed Case Handout	Shows how the outputs connect from customer problem through evidence and governance.
Completed PR/FAQ	Provides the deeper model artifact for review and discussion.

Sources and status

This playbook draws on the approved Working Backwards project brief, the completed Digikala Instant Exchange illustrative case study, and Colin Bryar and Bill Carr, *Working Backwards* (2021), for general method background.